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Ethical Theory

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John Stuart Mill thinks we cannot know the nature of the two sexes because we impose rules, norms, and relationships on them that are unnatural and conceal their true nature. With these restrictions in place, it becomes impossible to empirically observe the nature of humans, particularly of women. Individuals behave very differently under different circumstances. If women were permitted to behave freely, they may reveal aspects of their nature that were previously unavailable.

According to Mill, we only see “one narrow part” of the nature of women. This can lead to a false sense of understanding. This part is likely to be a minor part of a larger whole. Furthermore, even though we can observe the physical differences, the mental differences are much more difficult to observe, and even among professionals, techniques are not refined. Even today, understanding the differences in the sexes based on brain structure is an inexact science.

With the advancement of women in present society, we may begin to see more aspects of the true nature of the sexes. While there are still many restrictions in place, and different problems today than there were at the time of John Stuart Mill, the differences in society allow us to observe something new. We get to see different aspects of the nature of men and women. That said, Mill’s reservations are valid today as well for a few reasons. The first reason is the same objection that Mill himself raised – that we simply do not observe women in different environments and societies. The second one is much more difficult to overcome – the subjective nature of human existence cannot be well understood, and one must experience it.